
DOMINIONS 6 NATION DOSSIER

Middle Age Pythium

Emerald Empire

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Unmodded 6.36 doctrine with source-labelled rules, strategy, and open verification work.

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Middle Age Pythium: Emerald Empire

Pythium one-page command brief

Middle Age Pythium turns a broad legion roster, powerful Astral priest-mages, a separate troop-queue communion recruit, and unusually high capital gem income into a flexible imperial army. Ordinary forts recruit nine commanders and twelve troop types. The capital adds the Arch Theurg, Hydra Tamer, Battle Vestal, Hydra Hatchling, and Hydra through two national sites.

The reliable core is easy to state:

- the legion roster ranges from cheap Slingers and Velites to Hastati, Principes, Triarii, and Emerald Guards;
- Serpent Cataphracts add a heavily protected rider and a separately tracked Armored Serpent mount;
- Theurg Acolytes provide S1 H1, Theurgs provide A1 W1 S2 H2, and capital-only Arch Theurgs begin at A2 W1 S3 H3 before randoms;
- Theurg Communicants are troop recruits with a printed limit of one per month and a pinned automatic Communion Slave field;
- the Cathedral of the Spheres supplies two Air gems, one Water gem, and five Astral pearls each month;
- the national ritual list contains six angelic summons plus Contact Lar and Awaken Hamadryad;
- repeatable recruits have no fixed Earth, Death, Nature, Glamour, or Blood access;
- the official manual gives Pythium an Order scale limit of +1 and a Fortified City at the start.

Pythium has options, but each option draws on a different queue. Arch Theurgs consume capital commander time and 565 gold. Hydras consume capital troop time, 200 gold, and a one-per-month slot. Theurg Communicants use the troop queue even though their purpose is magical. A strong plan names which queue is solving which problem before the capital becomes a collection of expensive pieces without a field army.

Pythium evidence and ruleset

The scope is unmodded MA Pythium on the Book I 6.36 live baseline. The revision-2 official manual controls the player-facing nation rules, printed roster, costs, recruitment locations, paths, national rituals, and mount statistics. Object identifiers, site fields, hidden random slots, national restrictions, item-rebate fields, hero records, and special unit flags are cross-checked against the pinned 6.35 Inspector export at commit `cfac4311bc0b58053b8dead7bffb036ba9bd5dc`.

The official update ledger through 6.36 contains one Pythium name match: a 6.07 correction for Epoteia that explicitly belongs to Late Age Pythium. It is not applied to the Middle Age nation. No ledger record through 6.36 names MA Pythium, one of its listed recruits, either capital site, or one of its national rituals as receiving a direct change. That is a patch-ledger result, not proof that no undocumented engine change exists; a current game card remains authoritative when it exposes newer detail.

Pythium conversion chain

fortified capital, legion choices, and eight capital gems
 -> target-specific infantry, leaders, and early expansion
 -> forts, laboratories, temples, and protected recruitment
 -> Acolytes, Theurgs, Arch Theurgs, and Communicants
 -> battlefield communions, Grand Communion, and national rituals
 -> legion support, Astral control, Air damage, and summoned specialists
 -> protected mage economy, siege operations, and Throne claims

The chain most often breaks when one resource is mistaken for another. Eight capital gems do not pay the gold cost of a Theurg. Cheap legionnaires do not protect a communion by themselves. A large communion can reach high paths and still fail through fatigue, slave losses, a dead master, or a threatened rear. Pythium works best when its army, mage turns, pearls, and replacement plan are budgeted together.

Pythian national rules that shape the plan

Rule or asset	Operational consequence
Order limit +1	Pythium can take a higher Order scale than a normal nation. The extra legal point is an option, not a command to use it in every design.
Fortified City start	The capital begins with stronger infrastructure than an ordinary starting fort. It still has only one commander queue and one troop queue each turn.
Standard forts	Expansion of the recruitment network follows the normal fort system; capital-only mages, sacreds, and hydras remain tied to their sites.
Powerful priests	Repeatable H2 Theurgs and the capital H3 Arch Theurg support religion and battlefield priest work; the pinned hero Bartholomeus reaches H4.
High capital gem income	The Cathedral produces A2, W1, and S5 each month, eight gems in total. Nature rituals and Nature-forged national items still need a separate Nature economy.
Grand Communion	The official manual uses Pythium's Arch Theurg, Theurgs, and Acolytes as its worked example for strengthening a public ritual such as Dispel. Joining mages give up their own activity for that ritual.
Separate communion recruit	Theurg Communicants are recruited as troops, printed at one per month, and carry a pinned automatic Communion Slave field. They ease pressure on the commander queue but compete with the army queue.
Serpent mounts	Serpent Cataphracts and Serpent Lords ride Armored Serpents with their own hit points, protection, and poisonous bite. Rider and mount outcomes remain separate.
Capital hydras	Hydras and Hatchlings offer regeneration, poison resistance, and multiple head weapons in the printed roster. The pinned record also marks poison clouds and other fields whose live operation remains open.

The strongest national features do not all point in the same direction. Legionnaires reward broad fort recruitment, while Arch Theurgs and hydras remain capital bound. Grand Communion concentrates ritual power in one province, while campaign survival usually rewards distributing ordinary Theurgs and replacement armies. The plan must decide when concentration is worth the risk.

Pythium capital sites and recruitment queues

Site	Verified fields	Recruitment consequence
Cathedral of the Spheres, site 3	Two Air gems, one Water gem, and five Astral pearls per month	Enables Arch Theurg and Battle Vestal
Swamps of Pythia, site 4	No gem income in the pinned site row	Enables Hydra Tamer, Hydra, and Hydra Hatchling

The Cathedral produces eight gems each month. This supports Air, Water, and especially Astral work, but not the Nature gems required by Contact Lar, Awaken Hamadryad, Gloves of the Gladiator, or Hydra Skin Armor. Search coverage, trade, site capture, or another explicit source must fund that branch.

The capital has two distinct decisions. Its commander queue chooses between the four-point, 565-gold Arch Theurg and the one-point Hydra Tamer, along with any ordinary commander. Its troop queue chooses among legionnaires, Battle Vestals, Communicants, Hydra Hatchlings, and the 200-gold Hydra. Monthly limits on the Hydra and Communicant do not create extra queues; they only limit those individual recruits.

Complete Pythium roster by job

Unit or group	Best job	Important limit
Slinger	Cheapest printed missile body	Morale 7, low protection, and low melee skills make it a support body, not a line anchor.
Retarius and Gladiator	Low-resource shock troops with net-trident or flail profiles	The pinned records mark both as Single Battle. Their current departure timing remains a live-card question.
Velite	Mobile skirmishing infantry with spear and javelin	Protection 7 and Morale 10 demand suitable targets and leadership.
Alae Legionnaire	Ten-gold armoured spear-and-javelin body	The cheap gold price is balanced by 20 resources and ordinary Morale 10.
Hastatus	Short-sword legionnaire with javelin	Eleven gold and 21 resources; its value depends on whether the weapon profile reaches the target.
Principe	Higher-skill, higher-morale legion line	Fourteen gold and 20 recruitment points reduce the number produced from a busy fort.
Triarius	Heavily protected long-spear line	Twenty-nine resources, 25 recruitment points, Encumbrance 10, and Combat Speed 6 make fatigue and contact central concerns.
Emerald Guard	Elite human bodyguard and line troop	Twenty gold, 30 resources, and 31 recruitment points make losses expensive; its broad sword still needs to beat the target's protection.
Standard	Legionnaire carrying the pinned Standard +1 field	Twenty gold for a support effect that should be placed where morale support is actually needed.
Serpent Cataphract	Mobile heavy rider with a poisonous serpent mount	Forty-five gold and 27 resources; rider and mount can be hit separately, and poison is not universal damage.
Battle Vestal	Capital-only sacred skirmisher	Low protection and nine hit points place a premium on bless design, positioning, and casualty control.
Hydra Hatchling and Hydra	Capital-only regenerating poison pieces	Fire Resistance -10, low combat speed, poison exposure, animal leadership, and friendly formation all need attention.

Unit or group	Best job	Important limit
Theurg Communicant	Troop-queue communion support	Fifty gold, 31 recruitment points, one per month, and unable to act independently while serving as a communion slave.

The legion roster is a set of cost and weapon trades, not a single ladder from bad to good. Alae Legionnaires put armoured bodies on the field cheaply in gold. Principes and Emerald Guards buy stronger individual profiles at a higher gold and recruitment-point cost. Triarii add protection and reach but also heavy encumbrance. Reports about the enemy should decide which mix is produced.

Pythium commander and mage portfolio

Commander	Paths or ability	Main jobs	Recruitment warning
Scout	Stealth 50, forest and mountain survival	Exploration and army reporting	Thirty-five gold and no leadership role beyond scouting.
Assassin	Stealth 65, Assassin, Patience +1	Targeted pressure and intelligence	Outcomes depend on the target, guards, arena, equipment, and rolls.
Centurion	Leadership 100	Ordinary legion command	Ninety-five gold and 21 resources; no priest or magic path.
Serpent Lord	Leadership 75, Skilled Rider 2	Command for serpent-mounted forces and mobile detachments	The mount is a separate creature and does not share every rider protection.
Emerald Lord	Leadership 100	Durable command and bodyguard work	One hundred twenty-five gold and 30 resources compete with an Emerald Guard group or infrastructure.
Legatus Legionis	Leadership 150	Main large-army command	Two recruitment points and 150 gold; high capacity has value only when an army needs it.
Battle Deacon	H1, sacred, Leadership 50	Cheap priest and small military command	No non-Holy magic path and only one priest level.
Theurg Acolyte	S1 H1, sacred	Lower-cost research, communion participation, preaching, and Astral support	Two recruitment points for a fragile mage with low battlefield skills.
Theurg	A1 W1 S2 H2, sacred, Fortune Teller 5	Main repeatable mage-priest, battle communion master, research, and priest work	Three hundred gold; using one in a Grand Communion also consumes its strategic turn.
Hydra Tamer	Swamp Survival and Poison Resistance 15; pinned Beastmaster 2	Hydra leadership and poison-aware support	Capital-only, Leadership 10, and no magic path; it is a specialist, not a general commander.
Arch Theurg	A2 W1 S3 H3 plus pinned randoms, Fortune Teller 10	High Astral ritual work, Grand Communion lead, Air-Water support, and high priest duties	Capital-only, 565 gold, and four recruitment points; the second pinned random is not printed in the manual.

The ordinary-fort mage line is the strategic backbone. Acolytes put S1 and H1 in every developed recruitment centre. Theurgs provide the fixed A1 W1 S2 H2 package that supports several schools without waiting for a random. Arch Theurgs raise the ceiling, but a plan that uses them for every magical job will overload the capital and leave valuable ordinary forts underused.

Reading the Arch Theurg random paths

The official manual prints the Arch Theurg as A2 W1 S3 H3 with one random level. The pinned 6.35 record resolves mask 2944 into Fire, Air, Water, or Astral and records two rolls:

- 1 one guaranteed level chosen equally from Fire, Air, Water, or Astral;
- 2 an independent 10% chance of a second level from the same four paths.

The mask components are 128, 256, 512, and 2048. The second slot is not visible in the manual's ?1 summary, so it remains pinned planning evidence without current 6.36 display confirmation.

Arch Theurg distribution

Portfolio result	Probability per Arch Theurg
No second random level	90%
Second level matches the first path	2.5%
Second level is a different path	7.5%
Any one named path appears at least once	26.875%
A chosen named path appears twice	0.625%
At least Air or Water appears	52.5%

For Fire, the result is at least F1 on 26.875% of Arch Theurgs and F2 on 0.625%. Air results raise fixed A2 to at least A3, Water results raise W1 to at least W2, and Astral results raise S3 to at least S4. A matching second roll can rarely reach A4, W3, or S5.

Three independent Arch Theurgs give about a 60.90% chance of at least one result in a chosen named path. Five give about 79.09%, and ten about 95.63%. Those figures describe a recruitment portfolio, not a schedule. The capital cost, four-point queue, survival, and arrival order still decide whether a threshold exists when it is needed.

Pythium native path boundary

Path	Repeatable access	Boundary
Astral	S1 Acolyte, S2 Theurg, S3 Arch Theurg, Arch random	Deep and widely recruitable; high ritual thresholds still require rare randoms, boosters, empowerment, summons, or a Pretender.
Air	A1 Theurg, A2 Arch Theurg, Arch random	Repeatable A1 and capital A2; A3 is conditional without a battle communion or another bridge.
Water	W1 Theurg and Arch Theurg, Arch random	Repeatable W1; W2 and W3 depend on capital randoms or an imported step.
Fire	Arch Theurg random only	No fixed recruit has Fire. Even F1 access is a random portfolio result.
Holy	H1 Deacon and Acolyte, H2 Theurg, H3 Arch Theurg	Strong repeatable priest line; the hero Bartholomeus reaches H4.
Earth, Death, Nature, Glamour, Blood	No repeatable recruit	Must come from independents, a Pretender, empowerment, summons, transformations, or another proved bridge.

The three pinned heroes do not fill a missing non-Holy path. Bartholomeus supplies A2 W2 S3 H4, while Marius Lorca and Hierogallus have no magic paths in the snapshot. Pythium owns two Nature rituals and two Nature-forged discounted items, but national ownership does not create a Nature caster or Nature gems.

Grand Communion and ordinary communions

The manual distinguishes battlefield communions from Grand Communions. An ordinary Astral communion needs Communion Master and Communion Slave in effect. Masters gain one level with two slaves, two levels with four, three with eight, and so on. Spell fatigue is divided among participants and then modified by the slaves' path levels. If every master dies or flees, the slaves receive the printed backlash.

Theurgs and Acolytes can cast the Thaumaturgy 1 communion spells because they have Astral magic. The pinned Communicant field places that troop into the slave role automatically. This saves a setup action but also means a Communicant is not an independent battle caster. Exact survival still depends on master spells, slave paths, fatigue, resistances, buffs, battlefield timing, and enemy access to the rear.

Grand Communion is a strategic ritual order. The official example has an Arch Theurg cast Dispel while Theurgs and Acolytes in the province add their Astral levels. Each helper gives up its own activity for the turn. Grand Communion can make a key public ritual stronger, but it also concentrates mages and opportunity cost in one place. It should not be counted as a battlefield communion or as free ritual strength.

Pythium national rituals and caster access

ID	Ritual	Research and paths	Cost and result	Verified native access
477	Contact Angel of the Host	Conjuration 5, S3	7 Astral pearls; one Angel of the Host	Fixed Arch Theurg qualifies.
479	Angelic Choir	Conjuration 6, S3	15 Astral pearls; three Angels of the Heavenly Choir	Fixed Arch Theurg qualifies.
481	Heavenly Wrath	Conjuration 7, S3 F1	35 Astral pearls; one Angel of Fury	Requires an Arch Theurg with Fire or another S3 F1 caster; pinned native chance is 26.875% per Arch.
478	Contact Harbinger	Conjuration 6, S4	25 Astral pearls; one A3 H2 Harbinger	Requires an Astral-random Arch or another S4 bridge; pinned chance is 26.875% per Arch.
480	Angelic Host	Conjuration 7, S5	50 Astral pearls; six Angels of the Host	A double-Astral Arch reaches S5 only under the pinned 0.625% result; otherwise another bridge is required.
482	Heavenly Choir	Conjuration 9, S7 F2	144 Astral pearls; Seraph and choir host	No recruit or hero meets both thresholds. This is a late external-access project.
275	Contact Lar	Conjuration 5, N1	16 Nature gems; one W1 E1 N2 Lar	No recruit or pinned hero has Nature. An imported N1 caster and Nature economy are required.
274	Awaken Hamadryad	Enchantment 5, N4	25 Nature gems; one N3 Hamadryad	No native N4 caster. The printed summon also has map movement 0 and Research -4.

The angelic branch aligns with the capital's five Astral pearls per month and fixed S3 Arch Theurg. The first two rituals are directly castable once research and pearls exist. Higher thresholds depend on the actual random portfolio, boosters, empowerment, a summon, or a Pretender. Grand Communion is not silently applied to ordinary unit-summoning rituals.

Contact Lar is the main national bridge into a missing path family. The ritual needs imported N1, but the summoned Lar carries W1 E1 N2. That can create Earth access and reach the printed N2 requirement of both national-discount items once the relevant Construction research and gems exist. Awaken Hamadryad remains harder because it needs N4 before producing an N3 unit.

Pythium national item boundary

Two pinned item records carry a Pythium national-rebate field:

ID	Item	Construction and paths	Printed properties	Access boundary
41	Gloves of the Gladiator	Construction 3, N2	Magic Resistance +1, Strength +3, four attacks	No native Nature mage; a Lar or another N2 bridge can forge it.
269	Hydra Skin Armor	Construction 7, N2	Hit Points +8, Regeneration 10%, Poison Resistance +15	Same N2 boundary, with much later research.

The structured rows establish a national rebate marker, not the final gem price shown after every discount, forge bonus, and rounding step. The live forge screen controls that number. Neither item should be counted as an early national asset until Pythium has a legal N2 forger, Nature gems, the research level, and a safe forge turn.

Pythium national heroes

ID	Fixed name	Unit name	Verified role or paths
584	Bartholomeus	Patriarch	A2 W2 S3 H4; high priest and fixed caster for the S3 angel rituals
505	Marius Lorca	Hero	Mundane Leadership 100 commander with strong personal combat statistics; no magic path recorded
506	Hierogallus	Hero	Mounted Leadership 100 commander on Armored Serpent; Skilled Rider 3; no magic path recorded

Hero arrival is not a recruitment plan. Bartholomeus expands fixed Water and Holy depth but does not add Fire, Earth, Death, Nature, Glamour, or Blood. Marius and Hierogallus add command options, while Hierogallus retains the same rider-and-mount separation that applies to recruited serpent cavalry.

Pythium opening priorities

The opening should secure four things before chasing the expensive ritual list:

- 1

a troop mix chosen for the nearby independent weapons, protection, numbers, and terrain;
- 2

enough leadership to move that mix without tying a Theurg to mundane command;
- 3

laboratories and forts that can recruit Acolytes and Theurgs away from the capital;
- 4

a deliberate capital split among Arch Theurgs, hydra support, Battle Vestals, Communicants, and ordinary troops.

No exact expansion count is supplied. Alae Legionnaires, Hastati, Principes, Triarii, Serpent Cataphracts, Vestals, and hydras all face different risks. Map generation, scales, bless, commander, formation, enemy composition, and combat rolls change the minimum safe force.

The first additional fort has special value because the best repeatable Theurg is not capital-only. A new lab and fort can expand the A1 W1 S2 H2 mage line while the capital handles Arch Theurgs and site recruits. That benefit must still be compared with gold, travel time, resources, border safety, and the troops needed now.

Pythium recruitment packages to evaluate from reports

Legion core

Alae Legionnaires and Hastati provide affordable armoured bodies, Principes buy a stronger individual profile, and Triarii add protection and a long spear at a heavy resource and fatigue cost. Emerald Guards are the expensive elite option. The correct mix depends on the target's weapon length, damage, protection, missiles, and numbers; no legionary type is the answer to every province.

Serpent wing

Serpent Cataphracts pair a protected rider with an Armored Serpent carrying 28 hit points, Protection 19, and a poisonous bite in the manual. They offer mobility and a different contact profile from the infantry line. The mount can be hit or killed separately, poison can be resisted, and a 45-gold rider must deliver enough value to justify the cost.

Hydra group

Hydra Hatchlings and Hydras are capital-only pieces with regeneration, poison resistance, blunt and piercing resistance, and Fire Resistance -10 in the printed roster. The pinned rows add Animal, Undisciplined, poison-cloud, Beastmaster, and head-related fields. Use Hydra Tamers, separation, and poison-aware support while keeping exact cloud spread, friendly exposure, head loss, and regeneration behaviour open.

Gladiator reserve

Retiarii and Gladiators cost little in resources and have useful contact profiles, but the pinned rows mark them Single Battle. They can be considered for a specific urgent fight, not silently counted as a permanent standing army. Current departure timing and the economic value of that exchange remain unresolved without live evidence.

Pythium research response tree

Research begins with a battlefield or strategic problem and the caster already recruited. Pythium's paths offer several clean breakpoints, but a large list of reachable spells is not the same as one coherent army package.

Branch A: Astral control and communions

Thaumaturgy 1 unlocks Communion Master and Communion Slave at S1. Thaumaturgy 2 adds Mind Burn at S2, Thaumaturgy 4 adds Paralyze at S2, and Thaumaturgy 5 adds Soul Slay at S3. Acolytes, Theurgs, and Arch Theurgs cover those fixed thresholds in different numbers, while communions can raise masters further.

This branch is selected when magic-resistance attacks, single-target control, or higher communion paths answer the enemy. It is weaker when the rear cannot be protected, slaves are too few or too fragile, fatigue is unmanaged, or the target's magic resistance makes the expected return poor.

Branch B: Air, Water, and Astral battle support

Evocation 2 gives Lightning Bolt at A2, directly available to every Arch Theurg. Evocation 4 gives Thunder Strike at A3, requiring an Air-random Arch, communion support, or another bridge. Evocation 5 gives Stellar Cascades at S2. Alteration 3's Body Ethereal is available at S1, while Alteration 4's Quickness needs W2 and so requires a Water-random Arch, communion, or imported access.

The branch should be built around a named spell and formation. Air damage loses value against Shock Resistance, Astral effects can meet Magic Resistance or mindless targets, and short-range buffs require safe delivery. Research alone does not protect the caster or solve gem use.

Branch C: national summons

Conjuration 5 is the first direct national threshold: fixed S3 Arch Theurgs can Contact Angel of the Host, while an imported N1 caster can Contact Lar. Conjuration 6 adds Angelic Choir and the conditional S4 Harbinger. Conjuration 7 adds Heavenly Wrath and Angelic Host. Heavenly Choir at Conjuration 9 is a separate legendary-scale commitment with an S7 F2 access problem.

Schedule each ritual from the caster and treasury backward. Pythium's Astral income supports the angel branch, but high capital mage costs, laboratory turns, and pearl stock still matter. The Nature branch needs a new gem economy as well as a legal caster.

Branch D: Dispel and Grand Communion

Enchantment 5 gives Dispel at S3 and costs 30 Astral pearls before extra investment. A fixed Arch Theurg can cast it. The official Pythium example shows Theurgs and Acolytes joining through Grand Communion to add their Astral levels to the attempt.

This branch is a strategic answer to a specific global enchantment, not a routine use of every mage. The extra pearls, participating mage turns, concentration of valuable casters, and timing all need to be weighed against the global's actual harm.

Pythium battlefield packages

Legion line with Theurg support

A target-specific legion line supplies numbers and protection while Theurgs provide reachable Air, Water, Astral, and priest magic. Mundane commanders keep leadership separate from spell scripts. The package still needs a plan for armour that short swords cannot penetrate, flankers that reach the mages, and spells that hit friendly formations.

Communion battery

Acolytes or Communicants provide slaves while Theurgs or Arch Theurgs act as masters chosen for specific path thresholds. Guards, spacing, fatigue planning, and a retreat route are part of the package. Adding more masters can multiply slave fatigue, and a master collapse can trigger backlash; size alone does not make the communion safe.

Hydra containment group

Hydras occupy a separate pressure role with regeneration, fear on the full Hydra, head attacks, and poison. A Hydra Tamer supplies the pinned Beastmaster role. Ordinary legionnaires do not have printed Poison Resistance, so formation and separation matter. Fire damage, poison resistance, low combat speed, animal leadership, and hostile control can all reduce the group's value.

Serpent flank and reserve

Serpent Cataphracts move and contact differently from the legions, while a Serpent Lord can lead a mounted detachment. Use them where their speed, rider profile, and mount attack solve a real positioning problem. Do not treat 19 mount protection as immunity or assume a dismounted rider retains the same battle plan.

Pythium Pretender families

Family	What it solves	What it must not conceal
Economy and production	Funds 300-gold Theurgs, 565-gold Arch Theurgs, forts, and resource-heavy elites	Extra income does not create capital commander turns, and extra resources do not pay mage gold.
Missing Nature and Earth bridge	Casts Contact Lar, starts Nature income, and can open the two national-discount items	One Pretender does not create distributed sites, spare gems, or replacement forgers.
Other missing-path bridge	Adds Death, Glamour, Blood, dependable Fire, or another map-specific need	A theoretical late spell is not useful without research, gems, availability, and delivery.
Sacred combat design	Improves Battle Vestals and sacred mage-priests	Most legionnaires, Serpent Cataphracts, and hydras receive no bless.
Resistance and communion safety	Helps sacred participants survive shock, poison, magic-resistance attacks, or fatigue pressure	A bless cannot fix poor slave ratios, exposed masters, bad scripts, or mundane troop losses.
Awake expander	Supplies early independent-taking power and preserves legion recruitment	Afflictions, counters, delayed scales, and an unavailable god can erase the early gain.
Astral ritual specialist	Strengthens globals, Dispel plans, and high Astral access	Pythium already has deep Astral; the design must justify what extra Astral solves.

Pythium often gains more from a missing bridge or economy plan than from repeating fixed S3 access. A Pretender path should have a first search target, first ritual or item, gem source, and backup plan. The Order +1 limit is useful only if the complete scale and awakening design benefits from it.

Pythium matchup and failure matrix

Enemy problem	First answer to examine	Avoid
Massed ordinary infantry	Legion depth, javelins, standards, buffs, and area magic	Paying elite prices everywhere when cheaper bodies hold the required ground.

Enemy problem	First answer to examine	Avoid
Heavy armour	Higher-damage weapons, Astral control, Air magic, summons, buffs, and target-specific counters	Assuming more short swords will solve protection they cannot penetrate.
High Defence, ethereal, or Glamour targets	Area effects, attack support, magic weapons, Astral tools, and imported counters	Relying on one expensive melee wing to make clean contact.
High Magic Resistance or mindless units	Physical pressure, Air damage, buffs, summons, and non-MR effects	Building the whole battle around Mind Burn, Paralyze, or Soul Slay.
Shock-resistant armies	Astral, Water, mundane weapons, summons, and other imported damage	Treating Air research as universal because Arch Theurgs have A2.
Poison-resistant, undead, or inanimate armies	Legion damage, priest magic, Astral-Air packages, and non-poison summons	Buying hydras for poison value the target largely ignores.
Fast flankers, flyers, and assassins	Guards, reserves, dispersed mages, protected routes, and mundane commanders	Placing every communion master and slave in one open rear cluster.
Giants, tramlers, and dense shock forces	Long weapons, depth, control, buffs, poison where legal, and reserve lines	Assuming formation density alone will hold a much larger contact profile.
Raids and dispersed pressure	Centurions, Serpent Lords, forts, scouts, local troops, and replacement Theurgs	Keeping all magical capacity and mobile forces in the capital.
Underwater objectives	Amphibious independents or summons, items, and a separate logistics plan	Treating W1 mages or a swimming hydra as proof of army-scale underwater access.

Monthly Pythium audit

- Is each fort limited by gold, resources, recruitment points, commander time, or travel distance?
- Does the legion mix answer the weapons, armour, numbers, and terrain actually reported nearby?
- Is a mundane commander available so a Theurg can keep its research or battle role?
- What is the capital commander queue buying this month, and why is it more urgent than the alternative?
- Are Communicants, Hydras, and other capital troops competing for a planned share of the troop queue?
- Has every Arch Theurg been labelled by its final displayed paths?
- Does each communion have named masters, slaves, path thresholds, guards, fatigue limits, and a retreat plan?
- Are Grand Communion helpers giving up turns for a ritual worth that cost?
- Does the current research target have a legal caster and a force that can use it?
- Are Air, Water, Astral, and Nature treasuries being treated as separate economies?
- Are hydras kept with appropriate leadership and away from unsupported poison-vulnerable troops?
- Can forts outside the capital replace Theurgs if the main army or capital is threatened?

Pythium unresolved evidence boundary

The following claims remain open:

- 1 exact expansion-party ranges for each legion mix, Serpent Cataphracts, Battle Vestals, and hydras;
- 2 live 6.36 confirmation of the Arch Theurg's pinned 10% second random, which the manual does not display;
- 3 the current unit-card display and automatic battle behaviour of the Communicant's pinned Communion Slave field;

- 4 exact Hydra and Hydra Hatchling poison-cloud spread, friendly exposure, head-loss thresholds, regeneration, and recovery sequence;
- 5 current Single Battle departure timing for Retiarii and Gladiators;
- 6 displayed Gloves of the Gladiator and Hydra Skin Armor costs after the national rebate, other modifiers, and rounding;
- 7 battlefield communion scripts, fatigue distribution in a particular spell sequence, slave survival, and backlash outcomes;
- 8 current Grand Communion participant display, ritual timing, and opportunity cost in a particular game state;
- 9 Serpent Cataphract and Serpent Lord rider-and-mount outcomes under specific attacks;
- 10 assassination, underwater access, Pretender designs, and matchup performance on a particular map.

These are evidence gaps, not invitations to guess. No runtime test or new test asset was prepared during this unit. R-047, R-058, and the wider hands-on testing queue remain parked until testing is explicitly resumed.

Dossier source register

Official

- Dominions 6 Manual, revision 2: MA Pythium nation pages; national spells and rituals; research; communions and Grand Communion; mounts; forging; and fort construction.
- Illwinter official patch history through 6.36. The only Pythium name match is the 6.07 Epoteia correction for Late Age Pythium, so it is not applied here.

Structured snapshot

- Dominions 6 Data Inspector, commit `cfac4311bc0b58053b8dead7bfffbc036ba9bd5dc`, pinned to the 6.35 data update; used for mage random masks, recruitment records, capital sites, national spell restrictions, national item fields, and current object cross-checks.

Interpretation boundary

Roster entries, path masks, costs, site income, item restrictions, and national ritual requirements are source facts. Openings, research trees, Pretender families, battlefield packages, and matchup advice are strategy. Expansion counts, live random displays, displayed forge-cost stacking, communion and Grand Communion outcomes, hydra behaviour, Single Battle timing, rider-and-mount outcomes, and other combat results remain observation questions until a versioned raw set is published.